

Think Big

Worried about your e-mail service provider going kaput tomorrow? Then you can sign up with an e-mail forwarding service such as Bigfoot.com or Pobox.com. Both of these allow you to forward all your e-mails to any e-mail account of your choice and you can keep on changing the forwarded mails option on a regular basis. Unfortunately, both of these are paid services, though Bigfoot.com does have a free, limited service wherein only 25 e-mails received every day will be forwarded.



The anti-spam features of Hotmail.com

sites such as Yahoo.co.in had spam protection as well, the only site that came anywhere close to Hotmail in terms of this feature, was Indya.com with its green list (addresses allowed) and red list (blocked addresses).

Addressing the audience

At a very basic level, an address book just needs the e-mail addresses and contact names. However, many sites have started providing for more comprehensive contact lists with phone numbers, addresses, birthdays and birthday reminders.

The most feature-rich address book is the one provided by Yahoo.co.in. You can export or import the address book in different formats, define four custom fields in addition to the various contact fields provided and even print out the address book for your reference. Chequemail was the only other site that allowed you to import and export address books, while Indya and Lycosasia only allowed importing.



Yahoo.co.in has a feature-rich address book

Functionality and interface

If you look at the address book functionality that most e-mail service providers have designed, you realise that programmers don't really bother as much about the interface as with providing for functionality. Take for instance the case of Indya, after you've done with adding e-mail addresses to the address book, you cannot select more than one e-mail address while sending an e-mail. Worse, the Compose Message option doesn't have access to the address book at all. Most sites don't provide an option for adding addresses from received messages to your address book.

In this respect, Hotmail really scores in terms of the overall interface. You can select the Add to Address book feature when you receive a message (or even when you send a message). You can select addresses from a quick list while composing messages. Though Geek and Chequemail are also totally functional in this respect, they lack in aesthetic design. While composing a message

in Yahoo.co.in and Indiatimes, the address book opens in a new window from where you can select the entries.

Address book apart, Hotmail has the best-designed interface (it underwent a design change in July 2001) with all the options made accessible within a narrow rectangular frame or within eye range. This means that you don't have to scroll or move the mouse around much. The only time you would probably have to move the mouse a bit further is while signing out. Guess Hotmail feels that signing out is something very few people will do! Almost all sites have the option for changing the interface, and Sify.com and Lycosasia even offer skins that change the entire look and feel.

Signing off

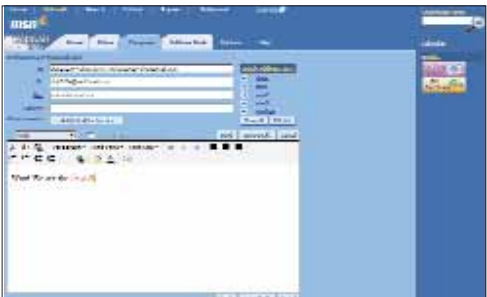
Signatures are a great way to show off your creativity—if this is important to you, you certainly wouldn't like Lycosasia, which doesn't come with a signature option. On the other hand, you might like Geek with its options for HTML signatures and the ability to remove the signature it normally appends to all outgoing mail. Rediffmail also lets you remove its default signature and Myrealbox goes a step further by not even having its own signature. Most other sites allow you to have text-based or HTML-based signatures in addition to the site's signature.

In addition, around half the sites we looked at provided for auto-replies or on-vacation replies. Indya is the only site that provides a template for the message, while Indiatimes and Yahoo.co.in allow you to specify the scheduled dates for the auto-reply.

Strangely enough, Hotmail, which has the most features, didn't have the auto-reply function and neither did Sify, Excite and a few others.

But the extra frills?

Apart from the basic e-mail service, these sites also come with a few extras such as calendars and reminders, spell-checkers, Web folders, etc. The frills you might especially like are the ones that come with Hotmail, Yahoo.co.in and Indiatimes. All three provide for a rich-text editor that allows you to send messages with different background colours, change font sizes, indulge in a bit of text



All options within your eye range at Hotmail.com →